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RAHUL WAS INSTRUCTED TO TALK ONLY OF LOCAL ISSUES DURING THE KARNATAKA LEG OF THE BHARAT JODO YATRA. CONGRESS BAGGED **16 OF THE 21 CONSTITUENCIES** BJY WENT THROUGH

despite the party going hammer and tongs at the Congress. The INDIA TODAY-AMI exit poll showed that 88 per cent of the Muslims voted for the Congress and only eight per cent for the JD(S). It not only blew away the latter's vote and seat share, but also demonstrated the limits of BJP's polarising tactics. Surjewala showed a message he had received from a wit that said—"Final tally: Bajrang Bali 135, Bajrang Dal 66".

The Modi factor, though, did ensure that the BJP retained its overall vote share of 36 per cent. Gupta estimates that the PM's blitzkrieg in the final leg of the campaign gave the party an additional three per cent votes, preventing the Congress from getting a two-thirds majority. While the BJP may have ceded 38 seats from its tally in the previous state election, the story may well be quite different in the Lok Sabha polls next year. Voters have in the past elected one party to rule the state and another at the Centre.

LESSON 7: THE PARTY MATTERS THE MOST

Finally, what worked for the Congress in Karnataka was that it was able to transform itself into an electoral fighting machine that could give as good as it got or even better in the contest with the BJP. Wisely, the party decided to showcase local leaders and local issues in the state rather than swamp voters with Delhi stalwarts as the BJP had done. It also demonstrated a rare unity of purpose where even the two ambitious leaders, Siddaramaiah and Shivakumar, set aside their differences and worked as a team.

Congress president Kharge, who hails from north Karnataka, played as significant a role. The octogenarian has been in politics since the age of 24, a career spanning nearly 60 years. He knew the strengths and weaknesses of the party in every constituency and of every candidate. Neither Siddaramaiah nor Shivakumar could unduly push any of their candidates if Kharge disagreed. The homework and scrutiny were done much in advance. It was also a prestige battle for Kharge as the election was happening in his home state after he became party president last year.

Congress itself had prepared well too, coming out with 124 names in the first list a month and a half before the polls. Every candidate had been carefully screened, their advantages and handicaps assessed. Siddaramaiah and Shivakumar were made to speak to rebel candidates and then open the dialogue themselves. As a result, the final list came down from 40 rebels in the beginning to single digits. The party also divided the state into five zones and put each region under a working president—Ramalinga Reddy, Eshwar Khandre, Saleem Ahmed, Satish Jarkiholi and the late R. Dhruvanarayana—and an AICC secretary. Based on Kanugolu's eight-month survey that identified around 70 "touch and go" constituencies, the party deputed observers for each such seat. A core team comprising Kharge, Siddaramaiah, Shivakumar, Surjewala and K.C. Venugopal did the micro-management and monitored daily developments in the last mile of the campaign. They were supported by the strategic team of Kanugolu and Senthil, who handled communications. Senthil's team worked in sync with the national communications team led by Jairam Ramesh, Supriya Shrinate and Pawan Khera. He was also the inhouse fact-checker, providing leaders with content to attack and counter-attack the BJP on various issues. A special Quick Response Team or QRT dealt with all the emergencies. Its strong campaign on social media and elsewhere, in fact, was one notable distinction of the Congress strategy this time. "We made the BJP play on a pitch we laid out rather than theirs," says Surjewala. "We kept on top of the narrative and were always on the offensive. It shows that the BJP and its leaders, Modi and Shah, are not invincible if we get our act together." With a wry smile, he then adds, "If you win, all the mistakes are papered over, and you look so good." ■